



**Dr. Strangelove's** sinister black glove, worn on his errant right hand, was Kubrick's own, which he wore to handle the hot lights on set.

"I can walk!" He is literally erect: sexually awakened, potent, and about to see his Nazi plan for a supreme race of humans, where there are 10 women for every man, put into action.

There is only one female character in the movie, Tracy Reed, who plays Miss Scott, General Turgidson's mistress-secretary and also the centerfold "Miss Foreign Affairs" in the June 1962 copy of *Playboy*, which Major Kong is seen reading in the cockpit at the start of the movie. In what was one of a number of "insider" references throughout the movie, the issue of *Foreign Affairs* draped over her buttocks contained Henry Kissinger's article on "Strains on the Alliance." The mix of sexual and military connotations persist between Miss Scott and General Turgidson. When

their tryst is put on hold due to the crisis, she is instructed to wait: "You just start your countdown, and old Bucky'll be back here before you can say... Blast Off!"

Many of the characters' names refer to themes of war, sexual obsession, and dominance, from the obvious Jack D. Ripper (prostitute murderer Jack the Ripper) to Ambassador Alexi de Sadesky

(Marquis de Sade). The bombs, too, have been named "Hi There" and "Dear John," signifying the beginning and ending of a romantic relationship.

### Superpower egos

In addition to Mandrake and Strangelove, the mercurial Sellers plays a third role: President Merkin Muffley (another sexual innuendo), who attempts to manage the crisis from his war room. In this vast, echoing forum, the US leader meets with an all-male cabal of diplomats, soldiers, and special advisers to decide the future of humanity.

The movie's central comic set piece involves Muffley telephoning Kisseff, the Soviet Premier, to warn him about the imminent attack; Kisseff is drunk at a party, and the conversation descends into petty squabbling. Sellers' monologue is hilarious, but also terrifying, because the "red telephone" had only recently become a reality. The hotline

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*Dr. Strangelove* outraged the Pentagon, though it was unofficially recognized to be a near-documentary.

**Frederic Raphael**

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